AI FOR MANAGERS · STUDY GUIDE

Why "Use AI If You Want" No Longer Works

Why can I no longer leave these choices entirely to individual team members?

MODULE 3 · LESSON 2 | ALIGN: BUILDING A SHARED WAY OF WORKING | Decision lesson · 8–10 min

THE CORE IDEA

AI choices shape the value the team captures, the capabilities people develop, the support they receive, and the risks the team carries.

That is why "use AI if you want" is no longer enough — and why the decision has become yours.

1 The instinct that got you here

How your team uses AI today was shaped partly by a management instinct that is usually right: trust capable people to find the best way to do their work. That instinct belongs in the **judgment of the work** — how to frame a problem, what trade-offs to weigh, what to recommend — and it stays there. But AI widens what one person's judgment touches: paste sensitive client data into a chatbot, and the whole team carries the risk; build a decision on an AI figure nobody checked, and everyone owns the result.

2 The decisions it leaves unmade

AI adds decisions of a different kind — the **shared conditions** around everyone's work: **where AI creates value worth supporting**, **which capabilities people must retain**, **whether access and support are fair**, **which tools and data are acceptable**, and **when output needs review and AI involvement should be visible**.

"Use AI if you want" sounds like trust, but it leaves each person to settle these alone — answers diverge, useful practices stay isolated, capability develops unevenly. The team fragments instead of compounds.

3 Why the decision lands on you

Some of these questions may already be answered above you. Where rules exist, use them; where unclear, ask; where absent, push the question up — don't write company-wide policy from inside your team. But rules can't cover everything; those calls are made close to the work. However much guidance you get, **how AI is used in your team comes back to you**.

4 Five risks that build when the decisions go unmade

Data security & compliance

Paste a document into an unvetted tool and the information leaves for an outside service under terms nobody read — and nobody decided it could.

Accountability

AI output arrives with no formulas and no revision history. When a wrong figure reaches a client, no one can show how the work was made.

Quality & consistency

The same tool gives one person a sharp draft and another confident nonsense. Quality under your name swings with whoever produced it; good practice stays locked in a few heads.

Capability

When AI handles the drafting and first-pass thinking, those muscles get used less. Lose the expertise and you lose the people who can tell whether AI output is any good.

Talent & fairness

People who got a head start with AI pull ahead for the wrong reasons. Left alone, the gap hardens – and you end up promoting access to AI rather than ability.

Plenty of AI use is perfectly fine – the risk is in what goes **unmanaged**. Each of these five traces back to a shared condition nobody settled, and lands on the team first, the organization soon after.

5 New work – and your opening

Past system rollouts were someone else's process: IT scoped them, training was organized centrally, you adopted what was handed down. AI did not arrive that way – the discovery and alignment happen close to the work, with you leading. That work is new. It is also your opening: Harvard Business Review research on AI adoption found that the **middle layer of management** – not the technology, not the executive vision – is where adoption actually succeeds or fails. Managers who lead this layer elevate too – the visible point where AI turns into real team performance. Not extra work bolted onto your role: your role, changing.

Julia Shin and Sandra J. Sucher, "AI Adoption Is Overloading Your Middle Managers," Harvard Business Review.

WHAT TO DO DIFFERENTLY AFTER THIS LESSON

- Keep professional judgment with the team – the reframe is about the **scope of the decision**, not trust.
- Stop offering "use AI if you want" as trust – it hands people a team-level decision they can't make alone.
- Apply the rules that exist, ask where unclear, escalate where absent – and own the rest.
- Settle the five shared conditions once, visibly – without prescribing every individual use.
- Change the stance first: these decisions are yours to lead.

Module 3 · Align: Building a Shared Way of Working – this module turns the picture from Assess into one shared Team Working Standard. **Next: Lesson 3.3 – How to Build the Team Working Standard – Layer 1** – the five agreements, built with your team in one focused conversation.